

Φίλων ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεύς

Philo of Alexandria on Moses, Abraham, and the Law

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Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)
Dialect: Κοινή φιλοσοφική [Philosophical Koine](#)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)
Affiliation: [Jewish](#)

Philo of Alexandria was a Jewish philosopher and biblical commentator who lived from about 20 BCE to 50 CE. He belonged to a wealthy and politically influential family in Alexandria, Egypt, the premier center of Greek culture in his era. Philo received a thorough education in Greek philosophy, with particular emphasis on Plato and the Stoics, while maintaining a steadfast commitment to his Jewish faith and scriptures. The most well-documented event of his life was his participation in a political embassy to Rome in 39–40 CE. He led a delegation to the emperor Caligula to protest the persecution of Jews in Alexandria and to argue against the emperor's command to install a statue of himself in the Temple in Jerusalem.

Philo authored over 40 surviving treatises, nearly all preserved by later Christian scribes. His works consist largely of extensive commentaries on the Torah, the first five books of the Bible. They are commonly grouped into three categories: the Allegorical Commentary, which interprets Genesis through philosophical symbolism; the Exposition of the Law, a more systematic presentation of biblical narratives and laws; and historical or philosophical works, which include his eyewitness account of the embassy to Caligula.

Philo's historical significance lies in his ambitious synthesis of Greek philosophy and Jewish thought. He employed allegorical interpretation to demonstrate that the teachings of Moses contained the same truths found in Greek philosophy. His development of the concept of the Logos as an intermediary between God and the world proved especially influential. While his work had minimal direct impact on Rabbinic Judaism, it became a foundational resource for early Christian theologians, profoundly shaping the development of Christian philosophy and biblical interpretation for centuries.

Works (40)

- Κατὰ Φλάκκου · [Against Flaccus](#) · 152 passages
- Νόμων ἱερῶν ἀλληγορίαι μετὰ τὴν ἑξαήμερον (α') · [Allegorical Interpretation of the Sacred Laws, Book I](#) · 437 passages
- Πρεσβεία πρὸς Γάϊον · [Embassy to Gaius](#) · 295 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα Ἀδήλου Ἔργου · [Fragments of Uncertain Work](#) · 5 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Κολακείας καὶ Ἀρετῆς · [Fragments on Flattery and Virtue](#) · 15 passages
- Ὑποθετικά ἢ Ἀπολογία ὑπὲρ Ἰουδαίων · [Hypothetica or Apology for the Jews](#) · 10 passages
- Περὶ Ἀβραάμ · [On Abraham](#) · 231 passages
- Περὶ γεωργίας · [On Agriculture](#) · 141 passages

- [Περὶ Ἐνυπνίων · On Dreams · 473 passages](#)
- [Περὶ Μέθης Β' · On Drunkenness II · 10 passages](#)
- [Περὶ μέθης \(Α'\) · On Drunkenness, Book I · 178 passages](#)
- [Περὶ φυγῆς καὶ εὐρέσεως · On Flight and Finding · 201 passages](#)
- [Περὶ Θεοῦ · On God · 3 passages](#)
- [Περὶ Ἰωσήφ · On Joseph · 228 passages](#)
- [Περὶ φυτουργίας Νῶε · On Noah's Planting · 159 passages](#)
- [Περὶ ἀριθμῶν Ἀριθμητικά · On Numbers or Arithmetic · 239 passages](#)
- [Περὶ Προνοίας · On Providence · 67 passages](#)
- [Περὶ ἀθλῶν καὶ ἐπιτιμίων καὶ ἁρῶν · On Rewards, Punishments, and Curses · 137 passages](#)
- [Περὶ ὧν νήψας ὁ Νῶε · On Sobriety · 56 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τῶν Εἰδικῶν Νόμων · On Special Laws · 837 passages](#)
- [Περὶ γενέσεως Ἀβελ καὶ τῶν θυσιῶν · On the Birth of Abel and the Sacrifices · 130 passages](#)
- [Περὶ Μεταβολῆς Ὀνομάτων · On the Change of Names · 252 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τῶν Χερουβὶμ · On the Cherubim · 99 passages](#)
- [Περὶ συγχύσεως διαλέκτων · On the Confusion of Tongues · 169 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τοῦ Θεωρητικοῦ Βίου · On the Contemplative Life · 78 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τῆς δημιουργίας τοῦ κόσμου · On the Creation of the World · 144 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τοῦ Δεκαλόγου · On the Decalogue · 146 passages](#)
- [Περὶ γιγάντων · On the Giants · 60 passages](#)
- [Περὶ ἀφθαρσίας κόσμου · On the Incorruptibility of the World · 127 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τοῦ Βίου Μωυσέως · On the Life of Moses, Books I-II · 507 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τῆς μεταναστεύσεως τοῦ Ἀβραάμ · On the Migration of Abraham · 204 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τῶν τοῦ δοκησιόφου Κάιν ἐγγόνων · On the Posterity of Cain · 178 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τῆς πρὸς τὰ προπαιδεύματα συνόδου · On the Preliminary Studies · 165 passages](#)
- [Περὶ Ἀρετῶν · On Virtues · 185 passages](#)
- [Ζητήματα ἐν Ἐξόδῳ · Questions on Exodus · 72 passages](#)
- [Ζητήματα ἐν Γενέσει · Questions on Genesis · 187 passages](#)
- [Ὅτι Πᾶς Ἀγαθὸς Ἐλεύθερος · That Every Good Person Is Free · 128 passages](#)
- [Ὅτι ὁ Θεὸς ἄτρεπτος ἐστίν · That God is Immutable · 153 passages](#)
- [Περὶ τοῦ τὸ χεῖρον τῷ κρείττονι φιλεῖν ἐπιτίθεσθαι · That the Worse Is Wont to Attack the Better · 155 passages](#)
- [Τίς ἐστὶν ὁ κληρονόμος τῶν θείων · Who is the Heir of Divine Things · 279 passages](#)

Other Jewish Authors

- [Ἀνώνυμος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · Alexandrian Philosopher Anonymous · 1 work](#)
- [Ψευδο-Φωκυλίδης ὁ Γνωμολόγος · Pseudo-Phocylides · 1 work](#)